The Telephone Call

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The Telephone Call

The poetry anthology for CIE IGCSE contains 15 poems. Below is a revision guide to Fleur Adcock's poem 'The Telephone Call' from the Songs of Ourselves Volume 1, Part 4 anthology. You will find:

- **Overview**: a line-by-line breakdown of the poem, including its possible meanings and interpretations
- **Writer's methods**: an exploration of the techniques and poetic choices that Adcock has used
- **Understanding the text**: an exploration of the themes and ideas in the poem

Overview

Learn more about the meaning of this poem to help you to confidently answer an exam question on this IGCSE poetry anthology:

- The poem in a nutshell
- A "translation" of the poem, section-by-section
- A commentary of each of these sections, outlining Adcock's intention and message

'The Telephone Call' in a nutshell

'The Telephone Call' by Fleur Adcock is a poem first published in 1986. It concerns a conversation the speaker has with a mysterious caller who has told the speaker that they have won the lottery.

'The Telephone Call' breakdown

Lines 1–4

"They ask me 'Are you sitting down?

Right? This is Universal Lotteries',

they said. 'You've won the top prize,

the Ultra-super Global Special."

Translation

- The speaker receives a mysterious phone call

Stuck on something?

Ask questions and get help with exactly what you're revising.

Got it

suspense:
    - The fact that they ask whether the speaker is sitting down suggests that the news they are about to deliver is shocking or unexpected

- The phrase "this is Universal Lotteries" indicates that the call is related to some sort of prize:
    - Lotteries are typically associated with luck and chance, so the mention of this organisation heightens the anticipation for what the prize might be

- Also, the name "Universal" suggests that this could be a worldwide organisation
- The caller then tells the speaker that have won the "top prize, the Ultra-super Global Special":
    - The use of the **hyperbolic** language adds to the **surreal** and exaggerated nature of the announcement
    - It could also suggest that the prize is something extraordinary

Lines 5–8

"What would you do with a million pounds?

Or, actually, with more than a million –

Not that it makes a lot of difference

Once you're a millionaire.' And they laughed."

Translation

- The speaker recounts what the caller says

Adcock's intention

- The repetition of the word "million" emphasises how much money they are talking about:
    - However, the addition of the word "actually" blurs the difference between the initial prize of a million pounds and the even larger sum
    - The reader questions the **legitimacy** of the call as the caller has changed the prize amount

- It is important to note that, in these lines, the caller has not explicitly said that the speaker has won any money
- The caller then "laughs" at the end of the stanza, which creates a **sinister** and unsettling tone:
    - The reader is unsure about what the caller is laughing about
    - This makes the reader question whether the caller's motives are honest or not

Lines 9–13

"'Are you ok?' they asked – 'Still there?

Come on, now, tell us, how does it feel?'

I said 'I just…I can't believe it!'

They said 'That's what they all say.

What else? Go on, tell us about it.'"

Translation

Help me understand

Adcock's intention

- The use of the short, sharp questions from the caller reflects the sense of urgency and eagerness in their voice as they want the speaker to react to what they have said:
  - The caller is **dominating** and directing the conversation
- The questions that the caller is asking could suggest that he is **coaxing** the speaker and trying to bring out a reaction from them:
  - Again, it makes the caller seem quite sinister and their motives appear questionable
- The caller is using the **imperative mood** by placing the verb at the start of the phrase:
  - For example: "come on" and "go on"
  - This could suggest that the caller is forcing the speaker to interact and engage in conversation
- The caller's response to the speaker's exclamation of disbelief is almost mocking and **condescending** as they claims that the speaker's reaction is unoriginal

Lines 14–20

"I said 'I feel the top of my head

has floated off, out through the window,

revolving like a flying saucer.'

'That's unusual' they said. 'Go on.'

I said 'I'm finding it hard to talk.

My throat's gone dry, my nose is tingling.

I think I'm going to sneeze – or cry.'"

Translation

- The speaker describes how they are feeling to the caller

Adcock's intention

- The speaker has used a simile to convey the sensation of their head feeling light or detached from their body:
  - The image emphasises the **disorienting** and surreal nature of their experience and adds a comical element to the conversation
- The caller then prompts the speaker to continue expressing her emotions and the speaker then describes the way they are feeling:
  - The speaker's dialogue is reactive and has an almost innocent, truthful quality
- "I'm going to sneeze - or cry" contrasts with the slightly cold, forceful language that the caller uses

Lines 21–26

"'That's right' they said, 'don't be ashamed

of giving away your emotions.

Relax, now, have a little cry;

we'll give you a moment…' 'Hang on!' I said"

Translation

- The caller encourages the speaker to express their emotions freely

Adcock's intention

- The caller further validates the speaker's emotions by reminding them that they are "going to get a million pounds" re-emphasising how rare and extraordinary it is to receive such a large sum of money
- The caller encourages the speaker to "have a little cry":
  - This suggests that they are trying their hardest to elicit an extreme reaction from the speaker
- The speaker's exclamation of "Hang on" indicates a sudden realisation and the speaker's need to address something important

Lines 27–32

"'I haven't bought a lottery ticket

for years and years. And what did you say

the company's called?' They laughed again

'Not to worry about a ticket.

We're Universal. We operate

A retrospective Chances Module."

Translation

- The speaker realises that they have not bought a lottery ticket and the conversation continues

Adcock's intention

- The speaker begins to doubt the legitimacy of the win as they realise that they have not participated in a lottery draw for quite some time
- The laughter of the caller is clearly an attempt to disregard the speaker's questions and adds a layer of **ambiguity**:
  - We do not know if they are dismissing the speaker's scepticism or attempting to manipulate the speaker
- The caller attempts to regain control of the conversation by explaining the mechanisms behind their company:
  - The explanation is an attempt to reassure the speaker about the validity of their win despite not buying a ticket recently

Lines 33–37

"Nearly everyone's bought a ticket

in some lottery or another,

once at least. We buy up the files,

feed the names into our computer,

- The caller explains how their company works

Adcock's intention

- The representative explains how the company operates and suggests that lottery participation is a common experience, implying that most people have bought a lottery ticket at least once in their lives:
  - This observation underscores the widespread appeal of lotteries and their role as a form of entertainment or a glimmer of hope for many individuals

- By detailing the steps involved in selecting a lucky individual, the speaker provides a behind-the-scenes glimpse into an otherwise **enigmatic** aspect of lottery operations:
  - This adds depth to the poem's exploration of chance, luck and the human desire for fortune

Lines 38–42

"'Well, that's incredible' I said.

'It's marvellous. I still can't quite…

I'll believe it when I see the cheque.'

'Oh,' they said, 'there's no cheque.'

'But the money?' 'We don't deal in money.'"

Translation

- The caller tells the speaker that they do not give out monetary prizes

Adcock's intention

- The speaker expresses their amazement and excitement at the news of winning the prize:
  - The **ellipsis** conveys the speaker's doubt and scepticism regarding their win

- The mention of wanting to "see the cheque" before fully believing suggests a desire for **tangible** proof of their win, reinforcing the surreal nature of the experience
- The caller responds by declaring that they "don't deal in money":
  - This contradicts the speaker's expectation of receiving a cheque and introduces a twist in the narrative

- This unexpected turn adds intrigue and uncertainty to the conversation, leaving the speaker and the reader questioning how the prize will be received or what it truly entails

Lines 43–48

"Experiences are what we deal in.

You've had a great experience, right?

Exciting? Something you'll remember?

That's your prize. So congratulations

Translation

- The caller reveals the unconventional nature of the prize

Adcock's intention

- The first line introduces a unique concept of prize distribution, suggesting that the company values and provides experiences rather than traditional material rewards:
  - It reframes the notion of winning a lottery prize, shifting the focus from tangible possessions to intangible memories and moments
- The caller's questions emphasise the **subjective** value of the experience, seeking validation from the speaker that the prize in indeed worthwhile and memorable:
  - By prompting the speaker to reflect on the excitement and significance of the experience, the caller reinforces the idea that the prize holds personal meaning beyond its monetary value
- The final line "and the line went dead" signifies the end of the conversation as the caller disconnects the call:
  - The abruptness of the ending adds a sense of finality and leaves the speaker to contemplate the unconventional nature of their prize instead of being given the chance to argue or ask questions

Examiner Tips and Tricks

Although the poem will be printed in the exam paper, you need to include references to the poem and use accurate, relevant quotations to show your detailed understanding. Focus on the key words in the question and annotate the poem with the question in mind.

Be sure to structure your response clearly and write your analysis following the chronological order of the poem.

Writer's methods

Although this section is organised into three separate sections – form, structure and language – it is always best to move from **what** the poet is presenting (the techniques they use; the overall form of the poem; what comes at the beginning, middle and end of a poem) to **how** and **why** they have made the choices they have.

Focusing on the poet's overarching ideas, rather than individual poetic techniques, will gain you far more marks. Crucially, in the below sections, all analysis is arranged by theme, and includes Adcock's intentions behind her choices in terms of:

Form

The poem is written in **free verse**, which means that it has no **metre** or rhyme scheme.

Theme	Evidence	Poet's intention
Hope versus reality	The poem is written in free verse and each line contains between seven and ten syllables, which makes them generally even in length	The free verse mirrors the conversational style of the phone call. As the poem mostly consists of dialogue, the free verse gives this an element of realism

Structure

The poem is made up of six eight-line stanzas also known as **octaves**.

Theme	Evidence	Poet's intention
Hope versus reality	There is no rhyme scheme as it is a free verse poem. However, the writer uses repetition as the word "million" is repeated four times throughout the poem	The poet repeats the word to emphasise the life-changing amount that was on offer to the speaker. However, the poet could be commenting on the fact that many people are concerned primarily with monetary gain, as this number is the thing that truly entrances the speaker

Language

The poem is almost entirely made up of dialogue and the poet uses a range of techniques.

Theme	Evidence	Poet's intention

	such as “incredible” and “marvellous”. However, when referring to the cash prize, the writer uses more **concrete language** when the speaker asks for a “cheque” before they believe they have won	distinguish between hope and reality. The abstract language highlights the speaker’s hope and excitement over potentially winning. However, the concrete language reflects her desire to see tangible proof before being truly overjoyed
Experiences	Positive language is used when the speaker is describing how they feel. For example, the simile “revolving like a flying saucer”	The writer uses the simile to highlight how the experience has given them a feeling that is “out of this world”: one that is a mixture of disbelief and shock. However, it could also suggest that – deep-down – the speaker believes the call to be far-fetched
	The caller asks if the speaker has “had a great experience, right?”	This question could be referring to the speaker’s experience of the phone call or could reflect something wider, such as a direction to question what is most important in a person’s life: monetary gain, or fulfilling experiences?

Understanding the text

The exam questions in CIE IGCSE Literature in English encourage you to express an informed, personal response. To do this, you need to have a strong understanding of the theme, main ideas, settings, situations and events depicted.

While context is not explicitly assessed, having an awareness of background information that is relevant to the main themes in the poem can help you develop a sustained, critical understanding of the text. You will also be able to demonstrate insight in your answer. To help you do this, the section below

- Hope versus reality
- Experiences

Hope versus reality

- 'The Telephone Call' was published in a collection written by Fleur Adcock in 1986
- The poem is about a person who receives a mysterious and sudden phone call claiming that they have won the lottery
- Throughout the poem, it is clear that the caller is trying to elicit a response from the speaker through questions
- The speaker is initially **sceptical** but slowly begins to become more absorbed in the idea of winning
- The use of punctuation gives us an insight into how the speaker feels:
  - The use of the ellipsis in the phrase "I just…I can't believe it!" suggests that the speaker is happy but in disbelief and so preventing themselves from being truly overjoyed

- However, when the speaker wants to see a "cheque", the caller reveals that there is no monetary prize but the actual prize was the "experience" itself:
  - This is quite **anti-climactic** for the speaker and the calls ends before the speaker can ask any more questions

- The poem could be considered a reflection of an individual's journey in life and the hopes that people may harbour:
  - Despite the reality of their situation, the speaker claims "nearly everyone's bought a ticket/in some lottery or another"
  - This could be a metaphor for life's experiences and how every person hopes for some luck at some point in their lives

Experience

- At the end of the poem, the caller decides to reveal to the speaker that the real prize was the "experience" as they "don't deal in money"
- This is **ironic** as the "incredible" feelings the speaker may have had are dashed by the end of the phone call as the million-pound prize ended up being non-existent
- The name of the company is "Universal Lotteries":
  - It could be inferred that the company is a metaphor for a higher power and the lottery is a metaphor for life
  - The call may be a metaphor for life's experiences and how it is filled with hopes, dreams and disappointments

- The message, however, of the poem could be that **superficial** and material things are not what ultimately matter:
  - The speaker is effectively being asked by the caller what things mean most to her in life
  - It is suggested that it is experiences that matter most and that those are what will be remembered

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